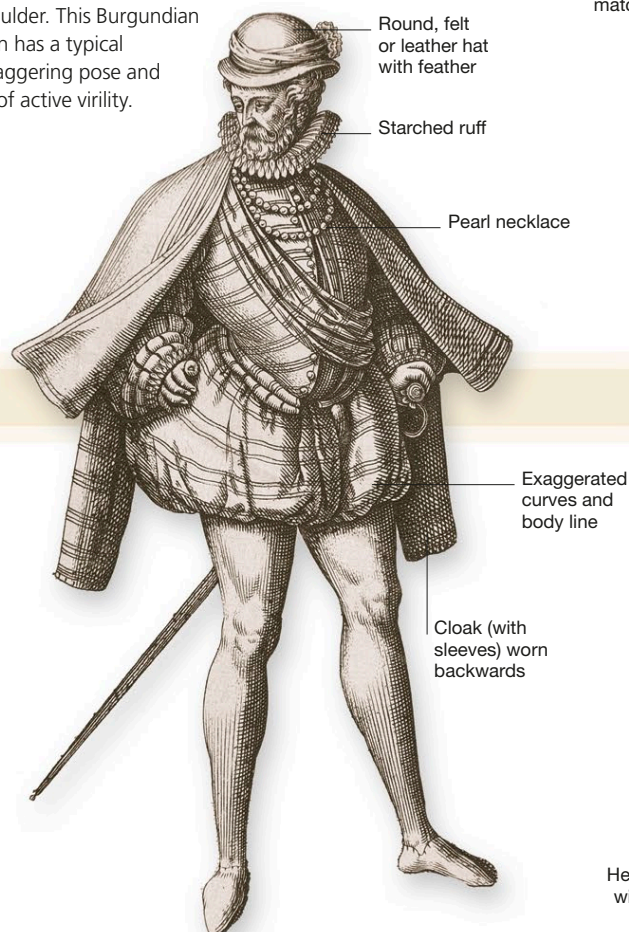


1590–1624

MALE EXTRAVAGANCE

As the tailor's art improved, the male body took on perfectly straight, rigid lines like those of armour, but created with cloth. Even soft ruffs were straighter, or disappeared in favour of straight collars. The new clothing changed the way people moved. Rigid torso garments with padded areas and exaggerated lines made it difficult to slouch or bend, though clever cutting left the limbs free to help men stride and indulge in manly pursuits such as fighting and riding. Fashionable men and women were equally matched in their ostentatious display of decoration. Both sexes coveted silk stockings, rosettes, ribbons, sashes, jewels, perfumed buttons, and, particularly, lace. Rich men could – and did – pour fortunes into their dress, or seek a fortune at court through the beauty of their appearance and grace in “making a leg”. Fashion moved from purely geometric lines to a new relaxed style by the 1620s, as breeches and hair lengthened again.

Striking a pose Men wore their short cloaks in many stylish ways: sideways, upside down, with the sleeves on their necks, or slung over one shoulder. This Burgundian man has a typical swaggering pose and air of active virility.



Glove gauntlets match doublet

Petticoat breeches

Silver-gilt garter ends

Heeled shoes with rosettes



Tailored geometry James I wears a suit with straight lines achieved by stiffened, tailored clothing. The doublet's buttons emphasize its precise lines, echoed by the cloak and the paned breeches. His square collar replaces the round ruff, and his shoes have the new latchet closing.

Straight doublet front

Hat brim widening

Falling band collar

Draped cloak has stiff lining covered with silk

Padded breeches

Stockings over tight hose

Latchet shoes with rosette

Huge expense In this 1613 painting by William Larkin, Edward Sackville's entire outfit reveals his wealth and position as the 4th Earl of Dorset. Each separate part of his body is decorated or increased in size. An ensemble like this one could cost as much as a house.